- The young child should be encouraged to eat with the rest of the family.

3.3 Packed Lunch for School Children



Packed lunches have become a necessity for school going children as schools are either away or the lunch period is too short for the children to go home and have food. The packed lunch is a lunch that is packed in a tiffin box to be eaten by the child while away from home. Carrying food from home is less expensive, more convenient, more hygienic and meets the individual requirements. Eating in the middle of the day, several hours after breakfast, re-energizes the body.

3.3.1 Points to be considered in planning a packed lunch.

- The school lunch should meet one third daily requirement in calories, protein and other nutrients of the child, to boost concentration and energy for the rest of the school day
- Preferably the packed lunch should consist of all five food groups, though the number of dishes may be less
- Inclusion of one serving of green leafy vegetables would take care of one third requirements of mainly vitamins and minerals
- Some amount of good quality protein like milk or milk products like curd or paneer would improve vegetable protein or a combination of vegetables protein like cereals and pulses can be given for better utilization. Addition of egg also improves the quality of protein besides meeting many protective nutrient needs.
- To make the food appetizing, pack foods like whole fruit or butter milk in a bottle
- Monotony should be avoided in packed lunch. There should be variety
- It is sensible to have a different food in packed lunch than what one had for breakfast
- Containers should be clean and dried before packing the food.

3.3.2 Tips to encourage the child to eat packed lunch

- Involve the child in planning, preparing or packing the lunch box
- Make the lunch simple. Most children eat lunch quickly so that they can spend more time socializing or playing with friends
- Send easy to open packages, cut - up fruits and vegetables, roll chapattis with stuffing.
- Send small portions which he can complete during lunch period

3.3.3 Healthy packed lunches

- Vegetable pulao, boiled egg, tomato raita and orange fruit.
- Cheese sandwich or paneer sandwiches, with guava
- Stuffed idli with coconut chutney and potato
- Methi chapathi with thick dhal and buttermilk
- Chapathi, paruppuusili and carrot salad
- Cheese sandwiches or paneer sandwiches, guava
- Idli and kurma
- Curd rice, tomato or cucumber slices and lemon pickle

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